four years. The House of Representatives has more powers than the House of Councillors, especially in financial matters.

Constitutionally, the Diet is the highest organ of state power and is the sole law-making organ of the state.

Soviet Constitution

The state of the USSR, also called as the Soviet Union, was formed in 1917 following the Russian Revolution (Bolshevik Revolution) led by the charismatic V.I. Lenin. After being a Super Power for more than 70 years, the USSR finally collapsed and disintegrated in 1989–1991 mainly due to economic crisis.

The Russian Revolution of October 1917 created, for the first time ever a socialist state whose goal was Communism. Hence, the Soviet Constitution was the first socialist Constitution of the world. Since its formation in 1917, the USSR adopted four Constitutions, that is, in 1918, 1924, 1936 (Stalin Constitution) and 1977 (Brezhnev Constitution).

The constitutional system of the USSR was based on the principles and ideologies of Marxism—Leninism. Thus, the Communist Party dominated the entire political and administrative system of the USSR. It was in this respect that the politico-administrative system of the USSR was different from that of the UK, USA and France.

The salient features of the Soviet Constitution of 1977 are explained as follows:

1. Written Constitution Like American and French Constitutions, the Soviet Constitution was also a written one. It was drafted by a committee headed by Mr. Brezhnev. It had 20 Chapters and 174 Articles divided into 9 parts.

2. Rigid Constitution The Soviet Constitution was rigid in nature. It provided for a special procedure for its amendment. It could be amended by the legislature of the USSR (Supreme Soviet) by a two-third majority in each House.

3. Socialist Constitution The Constitution was socialistic in nature and laid down the foundation of a socialist state. It stated that 'the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics is a socialist state of the whole people, expressing the will and interests of the workers, peasants and intelligentsia, the working people of all the nations and nationalities of the country'. It also stated that 'the foundation of the economic system of the USSR is socialist ownership of the means of production in the form of state property (belonging to all the people) and collective farm and cooperative property'.

4. Federal Constitution The Constitution provided for a federal state consisting of 15 units called Union Republics. These units of the Soviet Federation were Russia, Ukraine, Byelorussia, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Georgia, Azerbaijan, Lithuania, Moldavia, Latvia, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Armenia, Turkmenistan and Estonia. The powers were divided between the Centre and the units. The powers of the Centre were enumerated while the residuary powers were given to the units as in the case of the USA. These 15 Union Republics had their own separate Constitutions conforming to the Constitution of the USSR and enjoyed the right to secede from the USSR.

Within several Union Republics existed autonomous republics (20), autonomous regions (8) and autonomous areas (10). They were vested with a certain amount of autonomy. Hence, the Union